

Aetiology & Pathogenesis

Causes of Disease in East Asian Medicine — the Six Exogenous Factors, Seven Emotions, Improper Diet, Overstrain, Phlegm & Blood Stasis

風 寒 暑 濕 燥 火

Fēng

Wind

Hán

Cold

Shǔ

Summer Heat

Shī

Dampness

Zào

Dryness

Huǒ

Fire

The Core Principle of Aetiology in EAM

Disease occurs when the relative equilibrium between the human body and its environment breaks down. Whether disease develops depends on the struggle between **Xié Qì** 邪氣 (pathogenic Qì — all causative factors) and **Zhèng Qì** 正氣 (anti-pathogenic Qì — the body's resistance). Disease cannot invade a body where Zhèng Qì is strong. *Plain Questions Ch. 72: "Pathogenic qi cannot invade the body if the anti-pathogenic qi remains strong."*

What Are the Six Exogenous Factors?

Wind, Cold, Summer Heat, Dampness, Dryness, and Fire are the six climatic changes found in nature. Under normal conditions, they do not cause disease and are called the "Six Types of Qi." They cause disease only when: (1) the climatic changes are extreme or sudden, or (2) the body's resistance is low. When disease-causing, they are called the "Six Exogenous Pathogenic Factors" (Liù Yīn). They invade the body from the exterior via skin, mouth, or nose. Diseases are therefore related to seasonal changes and living environment. The factors may also combine and transform into each other.

① Fēng 風 — Wind (Primary Yáng pathogen · Spring · "Leader of all pathogens")

風 Nature of Wind

Spring · Also all seasons

- **Primary pathogen** — Cold, Damp, Dryness, Heat all depend on Wind to invade. *"Wind is the leading causative factor of many diseases"* (Plain Questions Ch. 42)
- **Yáng pathogen** — upward and outward dispersion; easily invades head, face, and exterior portion of body
- **Rapid changes & migratory** — abrupt onset, wandering symptoms, rapid changes
- **Constant movement** — causes dizziness, tremors, seizures, convulsions, opisthotonos

Wind — Clinical Signs

- Headache, nasal obstruction, itching/pain in throat, facial puffiness
- Aversion to wind; impaired opening/closing of pores → sweating
- Migratory joint pain (Wind Bì syndrome)
- Urticaria — itching wheals appearing and disappearing
- Dizziness, vertigo; tremors of limbs
- Deviation of mouth, tongue and eyes (facial paralysis = Wind-Phlegm in meridians)
- Convulsions, opisthotonos (extreme)

Wind — Key Combinations

- **Wind-Cold:** common cold with pronounced aversion to cold, no sweating, tight pulse
- **Wind-Heat:** fever, sore throat, slight sweating, rapid pulse
- **Wind-Damp:** heavy, aching body; fixed or wandering Bì syndrome
- **Wind-Phlegm:** facial paralysis, stroke-like presentations
- Endogenous Wind (Internal): arises from extreme Heat, Liver Yīn deficiency, or Blood deficiency

Pulse: Floating · Tongue: thin white coat

② Hán 寒 — Cold (Primary Yīn pathogen · Winter · Contracting)

寒 Nature of Cold

Winter · Also other seasons

- **Yīn pathogen** — consumes Yáng Qì of the body → impairs warming function
- **Contraction & stagnation** — impairs opening/closing of pores; spasmodic contraction of tendons & meridians; impairs circulation of Qì & Blood
- Cold limbs, cold pain in epigastric/abdominal regions, diarrhea with undigested food, clear urine, lack of sweating
- Causes: thin clothing, exposure after sweating, caught in rain, swimming in cold water

Cold — Clinical Signs

- Pronounced aversion to cold; preference for warmth
- Pain — Cold creates contraction → pain; warmth relieves (important differentiator)
- No sweating (pores contracted & closed)
- No thirst (Cold = Yīn → no thirst)
- Loose stools; clear, profuse urine
- Pale face; cold limbs; restricted movement of joints
- Pale tongue, white moist coat
- Tight or Slow pulse (Cold contracts the vessels)

Cold — Key Distinctions

- **Exterior Cold:** sudden onset, aversion to cold, aching body, floating-tight pulse
- **Interior Cold (Full):** abdominal pain worse with pressure, cold limbs, clear urine, desire warm drinks
- **Interior Cold (Empty/Yáng Def):** chronic, cold limbs, fatigue, dull ache better with pressure, weak pulse
- Cold can transform into Heat when it penetrates interior
- Endogenous Cold: arises from Yáng deficiency (internal)

Pulse: Floating-Tight (Exterior) · Deep-Tight (Interior Full) · Weak-Slow (Interior Empty)

③ Shǔ 暑 — Summer Heat (Pure Yáng · Summer ONLY · Always External)

暑 Nature of Summer Heat

Summer ONLY — unique among the six

- **Yáng pathogen** — transformed from extreme Fire; only occurs in summer (no endogenous form)
- **Extreme heat** — upward direction, dispersion, consumes body fluids
- Usually affects head and eyes; causes pores to stay open → excessive sweating → consumes Qì & fluids
- Causes: overexposure to blazing sun, working in poorly ventilated places in high heat

Summer Heat — Clinical Signs

- High fever; restlessness; thirst (strong desire to drink); profuse sweating; surging pulse
- Dizziness; blurred vision (affects head/eyes)
- Dry mouth; scanty dark urine (consumes fluids)
- Reluctance to speak; lassitude (Qì deficiency from sweating)
- **Sunstroke:** sudden collapse, loss of consciousness

Summer Heat — Combinations

- **Summer Heat + Damp** (very common — summer is humid): dizziness, heaviness in head, chest suffocation, nausea, poor appetite, lassitude + fever, restlessness, thirst
- No endogenous Summer Heat (pure exogenous only)
- Distinguished from other Heat by: seasonal context (summer only), strong fluid consumption, Qì deficiency concurrent

Pulse: Surging-Rapid · Tongue: Red, dry coat

④ Shī 濕 — Dampness (Yīn pathogen · Late Summer · Sticky & Stagnant)

濕 Nature of Dampness

Late Summer · Also damp environments

- **Yīn pathogen** — impairs Yáng; easily obstructs Qì circulation
- **Heaviness & turbidity** — dizziness, head wrapped in cloth sensation, heaviness of body & joints, soreness & pain
- **Viscous & stagnant** — stubborn sticky tongue coating; difficult stools; obstructed urination; diseases tend to be prolonged and intractable
- Spleen likes dryness; pathogenic Damp impairs Spleen Yáng

Dampness — Clinical Signs

- Heaviness of body; head feels wrapped in cloth
- Full sensation in chest; epigastric distention
- Difficult and scanty urination; viscous stools
- Turbid discharges — suppurating sores, weeping eczema, profuse purulent leucorrhoea with foul odour
- Turbid urine; stools with mucus and blood
- Poor appetite; loose stools; oedema (Spleen Yáng impaired)

Dampness — Key Points

- Causes: living in damp places, wearing damp clothes, frequent exposure to water, prolonged rain, Late Summer season
- **Damp + Cold:** Fixed Bì syndrome; abdominal pain worse with cold
- **Damp + Heat:** jaundice; turbid urine; yellow greasy coat
- Endogenous Dampness: arises from Spleen deficiency failing to transform fluids
- Stubborn, difficult to treat — "Damp fever" (intestinal typhoid), eczema = protracted

Pulse: Slippery or Soggy · Tongue: Sticky/greasy coat

⑤ Zào 燥 — Dryness (Consumes fluids · Autumn · "Delicate Lung")

燥

Nature of Dryness

Autumn · Dry climates

- Consumes body fluids → universal sign: **dryness**
- Often impairs the Lung — the "delicate" Zang; dispersing and descending functions impaired
- Invades Lung through nose or mouth
- Causes: dry climate, autumn season, air conditioning, dry environments

Dryness — Clinical Signs

- Dryness of nose and throat; dry mouth with thirst
- Chapped lips; wrinkled skin; withered body hair
- Constipation; reduced urination
- Dry cough with scanty, sticky or bloody sputum (Lung impaired)
- Thirst with desire to drink; dry lips and throat
- Dark yellow scanty urine (with heat component)

Dryness — Key Distinctions

- Cool Dryness** (Autumn early): aversion to cold, no sweating, dry nasal passages, dry cough — like exterior Cold but with dryness
- Warm Dryness** (Autumn late / warm climate): fever, headache, thirst, dry cough — like exterior Heat with dryness
- Endogenous Dryness: Yin deficiency, Blood deficiency, excessive sweating/bleeding/fluid loss
- Treatment: nourish and moisten (contrast with Damp — transform and drain)

Pulse: Fine · Tongue: Dry, little or no coat

⑥ Huǒ 火 — Fire/Heat (Extreme Yáng · All seasons · Transformation of other pathogens)

火

Nature of Fire/Heat

All seasons · Most severe of Yáng pathogens

- Yáng pathogen** — burning and upward direction
- Consumes Yin fluids** → burns fluids out of the body → dryness
- Stirs up Wind** — affects Liver meridian → Liver Wind; extreme heat generates internal wind (high fever → convulsions)
- Disturbs Blood** — speeds circulation; in severe cases forces blood out of vessels → bleeding; degenerates flesh → abscesses, carbuncles
- Fire, Warmth, Heat vary in degree — Fire most severe

Fire — Clinical Signs

- High fever; restlessness; thirst; sweating
- Mouth/tongue ulcers; swollen painful gums
- Headache; redness and congestion of eyes
- Restlessness, insomnia, mania, emotional excitement (disturbs Shen)
- Dry lips/throat; constipation; dark yellow scanty urine
- In extreme: coma, delirium
- Bleeding: epistaxis, haemoptysis, bloody stool, haematuria
- Abscesses, carbuncles, furuncles, boils (degenerates flesh)

Fire — Three Sources (Exam-Critical)

- ① **External Yáng pathogen** — Wind-Heat, Summer-Heat transforming
- ② **Internally generated** — from emotional stress or diet (excess red meat, spices, alcohol) → Heart-Fire, Liver-Fire
- ③ **Transformation of other pathogens** — even Cold can transform into Interior Heat when it penetrates deep
- Endogenous Fire: also called "Five Constraint Fire" — long-term emotional stagnation transforming to Fire

Pulse: Rapid · Tongue: Red body, yellow/dry coat

Season Memory: Wind=Spring · Cold=Winter · Summer Heat=Summer ONLY · Dampness=Late Summer · Dryness=Autumn · Fire=All seasons. **Yin pathogens:** Cold, Dampness. **Yang pathogens:** Wind, Summer Heat, Dryness, Fire. **Only Summer Heat has no endogenous form.**

Six Exogenous Factors — Master Reference Table						
Factor	Season	Yin/Yang	Key Nature	Primary Signs	Organ Target	Pulse · Tongue
Wind 風	Spring (any)	Yáng	Primary pathogen; upward & outward; rapid changes; migratory	Headache, aversion to wind, migratory pain, sweating, dizziness, tremors	Lung (skin), Liver (extreme)	Floating · thin white
Cold 寒	Winter	Yīn	Consumes Yáng; contracts; stagnates; slows	Aversion to cold, no sweating, no thirst, pain worse with cold, tight body	Kidney, Spleen, Stomach	Tight/Slow · pale white
Summer Heat 暑	Summer ONLY	Yáng (extreme)	Extreme heat; upward; disperses & consumes fluids; unique — no endogenous form	High fever, profuse sweating, thirst, surging pulse, collapse, Qì def concurrent	Heart (disturbs Shen), Lung	Surging-Rapid · red dry
Dampness 濕	Late Summer	Yīn (heavy)	Viscous & stagnant; heavy & turbid; impairs Yáng; Spleen hates Damp	Heaviness, head wrapped in cloth, sticky coat, turbid discharges, prolonged disease	Spleen (primary), Lung	Slippery/Soggy · thick sticky
Dryness 燥	Autumn	Middle (Yáng aspect)	Consumes fluids; impairs Lung; dries everything	Dry nose/throat/mouth/cough/lips/skin, constipation, reduced urination	Lung (primary)	Fine · dry, little coat
Fire 火	All seasons	Yáng (extreme)	Burning & upward; consumes Yīn; stirs Wind; disturbs Blood; generates abscesses	High fever, red face, thirst, bleeding, ulcers, mania, dark urine, constipation	Heart (Shen), Liver (Wind), all organs	Rapid · red, yellow/dry

The Seven Emotions — Qī Qíng 七情

Key Principle — Internal vs External Causes

The Seven Emotions are the **primary internal causative factor** of disease. They differ from the Six Exogenous Factors in that they directly affect the Zang-Fu organs, Qì, and Blood without first passing through the exterior. Normal emotions do not cause disease. Disease arises when emotional stimuli are **severe, continuous, or abrupt** and surpass the organism's ability to adapt. The Heart, Liver, and Spleen are most closely involved with emotional pathology. *"Anger injures the Liver, joy injures the Heart, grief & melancholy injure the Lung, worry injures the Spleen, and fear & fright injure the Kidney."*

① Anger 怒 (Nù)

Liver

Causes Qì to rise upward. Impairs Liver's function of maintaining free flow of Qì. Distension & pain in hypochondriac region, irascibility, belching, sighing, foreign body in throat, irregular menstruation. Severe: bleeding from impaired vessels.

② Joy 喜 (Xǐ)

Heart

Causes Qì to slow down. *Excessive* joy (not moderate joy) disturbs Heart's dominance of mental activities. Palpitations, insomnia, dream-disturbed sleep, mental confusion, in severe cases abnormal laughing, crying, mania.

③ Melancholy 憂 (Yōu)

Lung · Spleen

Consumes Qì; causes Qì to stagnate. Affects Lung (descending function impaired) and Spleen transportation & transformation. Epigastric and abdominal distention, anorexia, shortness of breath, fatigue, melancholy.

④ Worry 思 (Sī)

Spleen · Heart

Causes Qì to stagnate. Impairs Spleen's transportation & transformation → poor digestion. Can also injure Heart. Overthinking, worry, poor concentration, loose stools, poor appetite, fatigue, palpitations.

⑤ Grief 悲 (Bēi)

Lung

Causes Qi to disperse and weaken. Impairs Lung's dispersing & descending functions. Shortness of breath, spontaneous sweating, fatigue, susceptibility to illness, sadness, inability to let go, sob/weep without apparent cause.

⑥ Fear 恐 (Kǒng)

Kidney

Causes Qi to descend. Injures Kidney Qi → Qi descends → loss of bowel/bladder control. Dizziness, tinnitus, back weakness, frequent urination, incontinence, enuresis, seminal emission in men.

⑦ Fright 驚 (Jīng)

Heart · Kidney

Causes Qi to be deranged and scattered. Disturbs Heart (governs Shen) → palpitations, racing heart, insomnia, anxiety, restlessness. Distinguished from Fear (恐) which is more chronic; Fright is sudden/acute.

Qi Movements Summary

Anger → Qi rises ↑

Joy → Qi slows

Grief/Melancholy → Qi disperses

Fear → Qi descends ↓

Fright → Qi is deranged (scattered)

Worry → Qi stagnates

All emotions → can injure Heart (houses Shen) if severe

Other Causes — Lifestyle, Diet, Secondary Pathogens

Improper Diet (不内外因)

Type	Pathology & Clinical Signs
Overeating	Impairs Spleen & Stomach. Foul belching, sour regurgitation, distention, pain, nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, loss of appetite. <i>Plain Questions Ch. 43: "Overeating will inevitably impair the gastro-intestinal function."</i>
Malnutrition	Fails to provide basis for Qi & Blood → weight loss, weakness of four limbs, Qi & Blood deficiency, poor immunity
Overindulgence in cold/raw food	Injures Spleen Yang → interior Cold & Damp → abdominal pain, diarrhea
Excess alcohol / greasy / sweet / spicy food	Produces Damp-Heat, Phlegm, stagnation of Qi & Blood. Fullness in chest, profuse sputum, dizziness, bleeding haemorrhoids, carbuncles
Unclean / decayed food	Impairs Spleen & Stomach → abdominal pain, nausea, vomiting, borborygmus, diarrhea, food poisoning, parasitic diseases
Dietary imbalance	Deficiency of specific nutrients (e.g., no iodine → goitre; polished rice only → beriberi)

Overstrain, Stress & Sexual Excess

Overstrain & Stress

Consumes Qi & Blood → loss of weight, lassitude, disinclination to speak, palpitations, dizziness, disturbed sleep, shortness of breath. *Plain Questions Ch. 39: "Overstrain or stress consume the essential qi."*

Excessive Sexual Activity

Injures Kidney Qi → soreness & weakness of lumbar region & knees, dizziness, tinnitus, impotence, ejaculation praecox, lassitude, irregular menstruation

Lack of Physical Exercise

Impairs circulation of Qi & Blood; weakens Spleen & Stomach; saps body resistance → softening of bones & tendons, poor energy, poor appetite, lassitude, obesity, shortness of breath on exertion

Secondary Pathogens — Phlegm Fluids (痰飲) & Stagnant Blood (瘀血)

Critical Concept: Secondary Pathogens Are Both Product AND Cause

Phlegm fluid and stagnant blood are the **pathological products** of dysfunction of the Zang-Fu organs. Once produced, however, they further affect the Zang-Fu organs and tissues — directly or indirectly — and cause numerous further diseases. They are therefore considered a kind of pathogenic factor themselves.

Secondary Pathogen	Formation	Clinical Manifestations by Location
Phlegm Fluid 痰飲	Accumulation of body fluid due to dysfunction of Lung, Spleen, Kidney & impairment of water metabolism. Phlegm = turbid/thick; Retained Fluid = clear/dilute	Lung → cough with profuse sputum, asthmatic breathing Heart → palpitations, coma, depressive/manic psychosis Meridians, bones, tendons → tuberculous cervical lymph nodes, subcutaneous nodules, numbness, hemiplegia Head/eyes → dizziness, vertigo, blurred vision Throat → "foreign body sensation" (Qi Phlegm / Méi Hé Qi 梅核氣) Skin/muscles → oedema, heaviness Chest/hypochondrium → cough, asthmatic breathing, localized distention & pain Stomach/intestines → nausea, sticky fluid, discomfort, borborygmus
Stagnant Blood 瘀血	Impaired blood circulation due to: Cold, Qi deficiency, Qi stagnation. Traumatic injuries causing internal bleeding that accumulates and is not dispelled	Heart → chest suffocation, cardiac pain, green purplish lips Lung → chest pain, haemoptysis Gastrointestinal → haematemesis, bloody stools Liver → hypochondriac pain, palpable abdominal masses Uterus → dysmenorrhoea, irregular menstruation, dark red flow with clots Body surface → purplish/green skin, subcutaneous haematoma Common signs: pain worse with pressure, fixed; dark/purple colour; purple tongue or spots; Choppy/Wiry/Firm pulse

Pathogenesis — How Disease Develops (病機)

Core Mechanism	Explanation
Disharmony of Yin & Yang	Excess or deficiency of either Yin or Yang. Excess Yang → Heat; Excess Yin → Cold; Deficiency Yang → Cold (empty); Deficiency Yin → Heat (empty). Fundamental pathological change underlying all disease.
Conflict between Zheng Qi & Xie Qi	Zheng Qi (anti-pathogenic Qi) vs Xie Qi (pathogenic Qi). This struggle is the main focus of disease onset, progression, and transformation. Pathogenic Qi cannot invade a strong body. <i>Internal factor (Zheng Qi) is primary</i> — it determines susceptibility to the external factor (Xie Qi).
Abnormal ascending/descending of Qi	All physiological processes depend on proper Qi movement (up, down, in, out). Abnormal ascent (rebellious Qi) → nausea, vomiting, coughing; abnormal descent (sinking Qi) → prolapse, diarrhea. Disruption of normal flow underlies all pathology.

Exam Memory — Causes of Disease: External = Six Exogenous Factors (enter from outside). Internal = Seven Emotions (directly affect Zang-Fu). Neither Internal nor External = diet, overwork, sexual excess, trauma, phlegm, blood stasis. **Phlegm and Blood Stasis are SECONDARY — they are pathological products that become pathogens themselves.**